

primary 50-megapixel shooter is capable of capturing some impressive photos in daylight. There's a good amount of detail, pretty decent dynamic range, and slightly contrasty colours. The shadows do get crushed slightly in some instances, but it's nothing major. Portrait photos from the primary camera have some issues though. The edge detection is pretty decent but the details on your subject's face are almost always smoothed over, creating an artificially beautified look – even with Beauty Mode turned off. Indian skin tones also seem slightly more red when captured through this camera.

In contrast, the 2x telephoto lens fares much better with portraits. You get a more flattering focal length for portraits, the colours are more natural, and there's no artificial smoothing happening here. You can see a clear difference in the samples provided below.

Now, this 2x optical telephoto camera is great with portraits and for daylight pictures, however, its quality does take a dip in low light because of the lack of OIS. The primary camera does take pretty decent low-light pictures but its White Balance seems to be thrown off in some scenes. In the example below, there was no source of red or pink light in the room, but the whole picture has taken a pinkish hue.

So, both the primary and telephoto cameras fare pretty well in daylight – you get solid pictures with good colours, detail and dynamic range, and portraits are excellent on the 2x lens.

However, the ultrawide camera could use some work – the dynamic range is poor with the shadows in particular taking a serious hit to quality. As for the 16-megapixel selfie camera, I have no major complaints. It fares about as well as the competition with good pictures in ideal lighting. There's still no 4K video recording ability here though.

PERFORMANCE

The Realme 12 Pro houses the Qualcomm Snapdragon 6 Gen 1 processor which is built on the 4nm process. It comes with marginally improved performance over the Dimensity 7050 processor that was

used on the Realme 11 Pro. You get 8 GB of LPDDR4X RAM and 128 or 256 GB of UFS 3.1 storage. For those concerned with power above all, this isn't the phone for you. While the Snapdragon 6 Gen 1 can handle day-to-day tasks with ease and even some medium graphics gaming, it is severely outclassed by competitors such as the POCO X6 Pro with the Dimensity 8300 Ultra and the iQOO Z7 Pro with the Dimensity 7200.

Let's talk about synthetic benchmark numbers. The phone score nearly 600,000 in AnTuTu (v10) but phones such as the POCO X6 Pro and iQOO Z7 Pro comfortably beat this score. The same can be said for GeekBench, but the Realme 12 Pro does manage to score marginally higher than the iQOO Z7 Pro in the Multi-Core test. The phone got a pretty decent PCMark Work score though, meaning it is up to the task to perform general tasks such as working on Excel sheets, scrolling through web pages, etc. However, one good news is that the phone barely throttles its performance. In the CPU Throttling Test, the phone did not throttle at all in 15 minutes, which is impressive.

In GPU benchmarks, the Realme 12 Pro got some of the lowest scores in its price range and was even beaten out by the Motorola Edge 40 Neo most of the time. So, naturally, this phone is not the most powerful and should not be your go-to pick if your main concern is performance and gaming. There are better options such as the iQOO Z7 Pro that you can get under ₹25,000. And if you're willing to spend ₹2,000 more, the POCO X6 Pro 5G is blazing fast.

As for the software, you get Android 14 with Realme UI 5.0 on top. There's considerable bloatware present, but Realme has taken some steps to reduce it. For instance, the phone no longer forces app installation, and the folder of 'suggested' apps I despised on the Realme 11 Pro has disappeared. There are still some repeat offenders like Hot Apps and Hot Games that cannot be removed, but it is moving in the right direction. The company has promised two major OS updates and three years of security updates, but that does feel inadequate by 2024 standards.

BATTERY LIFE

Battery capacity and charging speeds remain the same on the Realme 12 Pro. It has a 5,000 mAh battery with 67 W fast charging support, the same as the Realme 11 Pro. It is a good enough one-day usage device that usually ends the day with around 10-15 per cent battery with moderate usage.

In our 4K video loop test, the phone lasted almost 12 hours, which is decent enough. It lost 9 per cent charge by running Google Maps for one hour, and 5 per cent charge when playing Call of Duty: Mobile for 15 minutes. All decent numbers. The phone takes around 52 minutes to charge from zero to full with the included 67 W charger. This is pretty fast for the price.

VERDICT

The Realme 12 Pro lives up to its promises, offering the best design and impressive cameras for under ₹25,000. While its low-light camera performance could be better, the design is nearly flawless, with the potential for improvement with a metal frame in the future.

This phone is striking and bound to attract attention from onlookers. However, it's not a jack-of-all-trades. Performance-wise, it's on par with its 2023 predecessor, making it less appealing to power users. Additionally, the battery life, while decent, isn't remarkable. Nevertheless, it shines where it claims it will.

For those seeking an elegant device with a good display and impressive camera capabilities, the Realme 12 Pro is an excellent choice.

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Snapdragon 6 Gen 1 | GPU: Adreno 710 | RAM: 8 GB | Storage: 128/256 GB | Display: 6.7" FHD+ 120 Hz AMOLED | Battery: 5,000 mAh | Charging: 67 W | Cameras (rear): 50 MP primary + 32 MP telephoto + 8 MP ultrawide | Selfie camera: 16 MP | OS: Android 14, Realme UI 5.0 | Weight: 190 g | IP Rating: IP65 | Colours: Submarine Blue, Navigator Beige

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